Figure 2.2 Galtung's structural theory of imperialism.

[**Source:** Adapted from Johan Galtung, "A Structural Theory of Imperialism"]

The two basic mechanisms of imperialism, according to Galtung, are:

1. The principles of 'vertical interaction relation', which involves the actual exploitative relation between the centre and the periphery.
2. The principle of 'feudal interaction structure' as a way of protecting the centre against the periphery, e.g. the principle of divide and rule employed by the centre to keep the periphery parts isolated from each other.

The first mechanism is the major factor behind the inequality, and the second helps to sustain and reinforce the inequality. The consequence is a continuous dependency of the periphery on the centre.

He further enumerates four rules defining the interaction structure between the centre and the periphery:

1. Interaction between the Centre and Periphery is 'vertical'
2. Interaction between the Periphery and Periphery is 'missing'
3. Multilateral interaction involving all three is 'missing'
4. Interaction with the outside world is 'monopolized' by the centre with two implications:

∑ Periphery interaction with other Centre nations is 'missing'

∑ Centre as well as Periphery interaction with periphery nations belonging to other centre nations is missing.

The operation of the two mechanisms just mentioned creates "subtle grid of protection" measures against any potential threats to the system, i.e., trouble in the periphery in the Periphery. The more finer and sophisticated mechanisms of imperialism are introduced within and between nations; there will be lesser needs to resort to oppression or violence and warfare. Galtung asserts: "Only imperfect, amateurish imperialism needs weapons; professional imperialism is based on structural rather than direct violence".